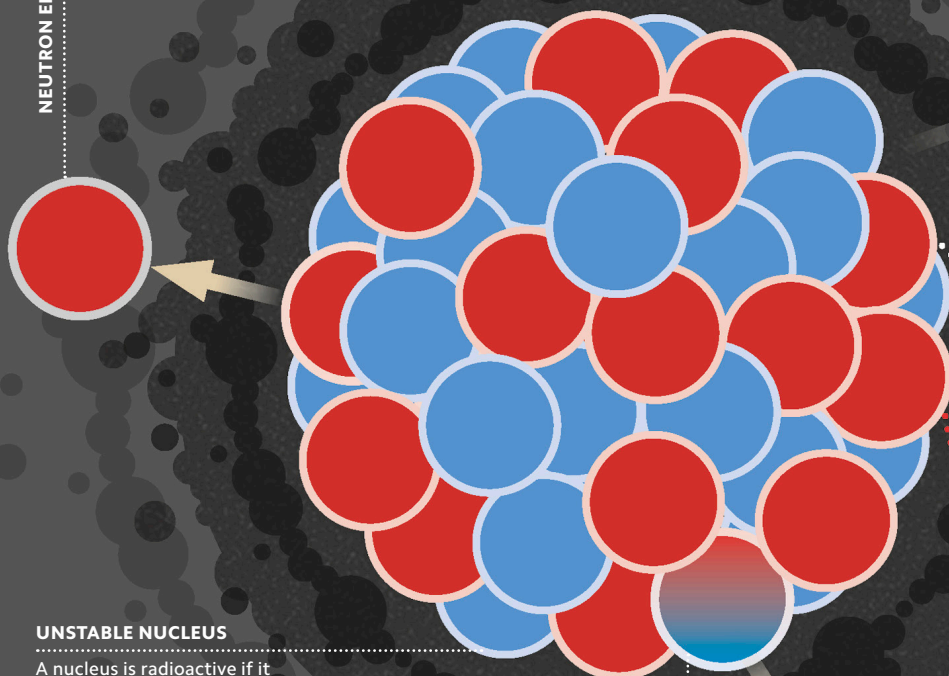


NEUTRON EMISSION

A neutron may also be ejected from the atomic nucleus during decay.



UNSTABLE NUCLEUS

A nucleus is radioactive if it spontaneously decays (emits radiation) to become a new, more stable nucleus.

Radioactivity was discovered by the French scientist Henri Becquerel in 1896 during experiments with X-rays and phosphorescent material.

β BETA PARTICLE

In beta minus decay, a neutron transforms into a proton, ejecting an electron and electron antineutrino from the nucleus. In beta plus decay, a proton transforms into a neutron, ejecting a positron and an electron neutrino in the process.

